



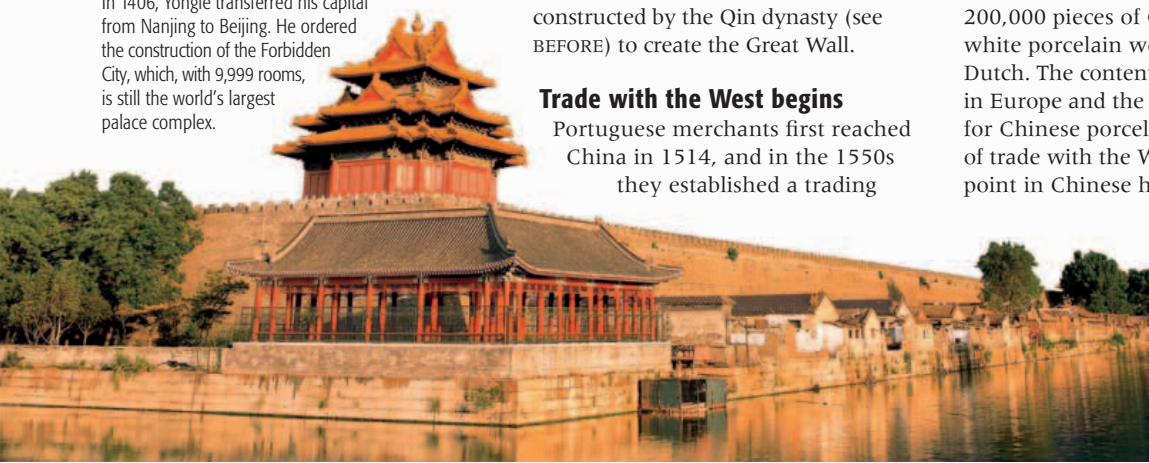
The Great Wall

In 1474, construction began on the brickwork Great Wall that we know today. More than 1,500 miles (2,400 km) long, the wall stretched from the Jiayu Pass in the west to the Yalu River in the east. The wall was strengthened and maintained throughout the Ming period.

Oirat failed to take this opportunity to capture Beijing, and Zhengtong was eventually released. Nevertheless, the Tumu incident heralded the end of the expansionist policies of the Ming dynasty; from that point on, frontier strategy became much more defensive. Lacking the military resources to control the steppe regions that had been the source of the Oirat incursions, a barrier was built to contain the

The Forbidden City

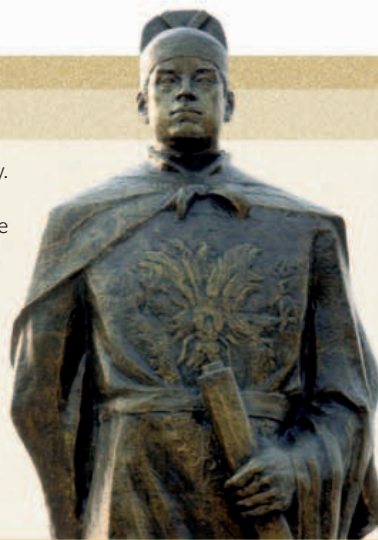
In 1406, Yongle transferred his capital from Nanjing to Beijing. He ordered the construction of the Forbidden City, which, with 9,999 rooms, is still the world's largest palace complex.



CHINESE EXPLORER (1371–1433)

ZHENG HE

Ming rule saw the creation of a vast imperial navy. Between 1405 and 1433, the Muslim eunuch Zheng He commanded seven ambitious maritime expeditions. The first comprised 317 ships and 27,870 men, and put in at several Indian ports. On subsequent voyages, he reached Hormuz on the Gulf of Oman, and ships from his fleet put in at Jidda in Saudi Arabia. Zheng He's voyages took him to 37 countries, and resulted not only in increased trade for China, but also in the capture of pirates that had plagued Chinese waters. An account of Zheng He's voyages was written by the Muslim scholar Ma Yuan.



Mongol threat. Brick and stone were laid over the earthen walls first constructed by the Qin dynasty (see BEFORE) to create the Great Wall.

Trade with the West begins

Portuguese merchants first reached China in 1514, and in the 1550s they established a trading

station at Macao on the southeast coast. In 1604, two Portuguese ships carrying 200,000 pieces of Chinese blue-and-white porcelain were captured by the Dutch. The contents were put up for sale in Europe and the auction set off a craze for Chinese porcelain. The beginnings of trade with the West marked a turning point in Chinese history; for the next 300 years, China's fortunes would be inextricably linked to its mercantile relationship with Western powers.

AFTER

The decline of Ming power and authority was a protracted affair. The Manchu Qing dynasty finally took control in 1644.

MING BUREAUCRACY

The Ming had the most effective central bureaucracy in the world at the time, but by the end of the Ming period, the heavy hand of imperial control, court intrigues, and factional fighting between groups of officials had made a significant contribution to the fall of the dynasty.



ADMINISTRATIVE SEAL

DECLINE AND FALL

By the late 16th century, the Ming dynasty was in decline. Weak emperors were **dominated by their advisors**, who increasingly influenced political decisions. In the north, a **new threat from the nomadic Jurchen** had arisen, as Nurhaci organized the tribes into the Manchu nation **240–41** >>. **Economic problems prompted peasant rebellions**, and in 1644 rebel forces under **Li Zicheng** took Beijing. Li was ousted in turn by the invading Manchus.